

Mauritania



A Muslim nation with a black minority on the Atlantic coast at the western end of the Sahara.

1896 Colonized by France.

1960 Independence from France.
A one-party state is established under Moktarould Daddah.

1979 Peace with Polisario in war waged over control of Western Sahara.

1984 Moaouia Taya takes power in coup, and wins reelection after 1992.

2005 Taya overthrown as president; first free elections in 2007 won by Sidi Ouid Abadallahi.

2007 Parliament outlaws slavery.

2008 The Dakar motor rally is canceled after the murder of four tourists.

2008 President Abdallahi, Mauritania’s first democratically elected president, is overthrown in a military coup.

Mali



Formerly French Sudan, the country is now named after the great medieval empire of the region.

700s–1050 Mali is part of the empire of Ghana.

1200–1500 Empire of Mali grows rich on gold and trans-Saharan trade.

1450s Empire of Songhay flourishes in the eastern regions.

1800s Fula and Toucouleur jihads spread from east and west.

1881–93 The French colonize the area.

1898 The French destroy Samori Toure’s Mandinka state.



Timbuktu
This remote city in northern Mali has been a major trans-Saharan trading post for centuries and was once a center of Islam. This engraving dates from the 1800s when the first Europeans arrived.

1960 Independence.

1968–90 Moussa Traoré is dictator.

1991 Traoré is toppled and imprisoned.

1992 First multi-party elections.

2009 Government forces capture main bases of Tuareg rebels.

Burkina Faso



A former French colony in the Sahel that is threatened by desertification.

1000s Rise of the Mossi kingdom.

1300s Arrival of Islam.

1890s French conquest overcomes Mossi resistance. Protectorate established 1895.

1920 Upper Volta is created as a colony separate from French Sudan.

1958 Upper Volta granted self-governing status within the French Community.

1960 Independence from France: Maurice Yameogo becomes the first president and bans opposition parties.

1970 New constitution allows for power-sharing between politicians and the army.

1983–87 Thomas Sankara holds power: his People’s Salvation Council (PSC) begins radical reforms.

1984 Renamed Burkina Faso.

1987 Blaise Compaoré rules country.

2005 Compaoré wins third straight term in office.

Cape Verde Islands



A former Portuguese archipelago, Cape Verde has been democratic and stable since 1991.

1456 Alvise Cadamosto a Venetian captain working for the Portuguese, visits the Cape Verde archipelago.

1462 Portuguese seafarers begin the process of settlement of the uninhabited islands. Slaves are brought from mainland to work the small parcels of arable land.

1600–1760 Ribeira Grande (on Santo Antão) becomes an important entrepot for trans-Atlantic slave trade.

1869 Emancipation of slaves begins.

1956 The African Party for the Independence of Guinea-Bissau and Cape Verde (PAIGC) is established by Amilcar Cabral and Aristides Pereira.

1961 Joint struggle for independence of Cape Verde and Guinea-Bissau begins.

1975 Independence from Portugal.

1991 First multi-party elections.

2006 About 7,000 NATO troops take part in war games on São Vicente island.

Senegal



An ethnically diverse state with a strong economy based around the port of Dakar.

1000s Rise of the Jolof Empire.

1100–1300 Becomes part of the Mali Empire.

1444 Portuguese, then Dutch and French establish trading posts on coast.

1895 Senegal becomes part of French West Africa.

1904 Dakar becomes capital of French West Africa.

1960 Independence from France.

1966–76 One-party state.

1981 Multi-party democracy restored.

2000 For first time since independence, Senegalese Socialist Party loses power to opposition. Abdoulaye Wade becomes president. Referendum approves new democratic constitution.

2002 1,800 passengers are killed in Joola ferry disaster.

2007 President Wade is reelected.

Gambia



A narrow ribbon of land along the river Gambia heavily dependent on peanut exports.

1200s First southward migration of significant numbers of Fula.

1661 British capture James Island.

1816 Britain acquires site of Bathurst (now Banjul) after a struggle for control among European seafaring countries.

1888 Gambia becomes a British crown colony.

1959 Dawda Jawara founds People’s Progressive Party; he takes power in 1962 and rules democratically until 1994.

1965 Independence from Britain.

1970 Republic is set up with Jawara as president.

1981 Senegalese troops help crush army coup attempt.

1982–89 Federation with Senegal.

1994 Jawara is ousted in an army coup.

1996 Yahya Jammeh wins presidential election, but three major parties are excluded from elections.

2001 \$2 million antipoverty program is launched by the government.

Guinea-Bissau



An impoverished, low-lying country that has suffered frequent military coups and rebellions.

1000s Four main ethnic groups—the Balante, Fulani, Manydyako, and Molinke—live in the country.

1446 Portuguese explorer Nuno Tristão visits the area.

1616 Portugal installs a military garrison at Cacheu to control the slave trade.

1879 Bissau and Cacheu united as Portuguese Guinea.

1956 Amilcar Cabral forms the African Party for the Independence of Guinea-Bissau and Cape Verde (PAIGC).

1959 Striking dockers are massacred in Bissau. PAIGC sets up its headquarters in Conakry, Guinea.

1960s PAIGC occupies large areas of the country.

1973 Amilcar Cabral is assassinated in Conakry.

1973 PAIGC declares the country independent, with Luis Cabral as president of the State Council.

1974 Formal independence from Portugal as the Portuguese Empire collapses. The PAIGC takes power.

1980 Military coup, in part inspired by resentment about continuing domination of Cape Verdeans in government.

1984 New constitution establishes the state on Marxist–Leninist principles.

1990 Multi-party politics accepted.

1994 Elections won by PAIGC.

1998 Army rebellion by Ansumane Mané leads to international intervention by other West African states.

1999 A transitional government is set up; the opposition Party for Social Renewal (PRS) defeats PAIGC in elections.

2000 Kumba Yalla becomes president. Mane is killed in a failed coup attempt.